



disqualification, but it's a trade-off Hillier and his team are willing to make.

"We're working on giving the runners the confidence to take the baton in the last 10 metres of the zone. That brings the time down significantly. As the chemistry builds and they improve, I want those exchanges to happen closer to the end of the box."

Simple in theory, complex in execution. Four sprinters, running at full tilt, in a high-pressure environment. Hillier is under no illusions.

"Putting the baton in the hand isn't the issue. The critical thing is timing the run-out. Most relay errors happen because athletes leave too

early. They get excited. When you see someone coming in fast, it's intimidating. You fear not getting out fast enough, so you end up going early."

Hillier has adjusted the baton exchange, starting with the outgoing runners' start position. The Indian team no longer uses the three-point start — a crouched stance with two feet and one hand on the track — because Hillier believes it impairs depth perception and causes miscued acceleration.

Another key change involves the mark, a tape placed in the exchange zone to cue the outgoing runner's acceleration.

"I have asked them [outgoing runner] not to focus on the chest of

the incoming runner, but on his feet. They have to imagine a small circle around that marking tape, and when the incoming runner's foot lands in that circle, that's when they have to set off," explains Hillier.

Under Hillier, India's sprinters have also made strides individually. Four of the six fastest 100m timings by Indian men belong to this quartet. Gurindervir set a new national record of 10.20 seconds in March.

Three of the four — Gurindervir, Manikanta, and Animesh — are under 25. Still, expecting any of them to break the 10-second barrier may be unrealistic, given how marginal gains become at the elite level.